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UNITY IN PUBLIC Uttar Pradesh CM Yogi Adityanath and Deputy CM Brajesh Pathak at a function in Lucknow, Nov. 7, 2024

▶ UTTAR PRADESH

NETA VS BABU TOURNAMENT

Top officials, MLAs, ministers spar in the open, even the Speaker has a go. The spree of public showdowns in Yogi's UP points to deeper strains within the polity

Takeaways

- **Kanpur saw two top babus face off in a spat that saw big netas joining to take sides**
- **As the latest in a series of such squabbles, Opposition calls it proof of camp rivalry**

MLC Arun Pathak and Govindnagar MLA Surendra Maithani wrote to deputy CM Brajesh Pathak, who is also the state health minister, defending Nemi, praising his "people-friendly" approach. On the other side, BJP MLA Abhijeet Singh Sanga demanded that the CM sack Nemi. Former BJP MLA Neeraj Chaturvedi joined in, taking digs at the Speaker for "trying to protect Nemi".

The Samajwadi Party was quick to seize the moment. Amitabh Bajpai, SP MLA from Kanpur Nagar, alleged "the dispute shows the government is involved in corruption, while it talks of zero tolerance". In a video statement, he said: "This fight is not between the DM and the CMO. It's between the CM and Deputy CM." MLAs taking sides only reflects camp loyalties, he said. Talk of strained relations at the highest echelons of UP's power pyramid is not new, and is often framed within the broader context of the BJP's internal politics and CM Yogi Adityanath's relationship with the central leadership.

Since his 2017 ascension, Yogi has consolidated his position with a strong, centralised style that has discomfited some. After his triumphant return for a second term in 2022, Keshav Prasad Maurya was retained as a deputy CM despite having lost his seat. And Pathak, a 2017-vintage BSP import and the one in the frame this time, came in lieu of Dinesh Sharma. An OBC and Brahmin face, respectively, they represent the BJP's keenness to project a broad caste base. The decision to have two deputy CMs is also often read as New Delhi's bid to curb all-out hegemony.

THREE-WHEELED CHARIOT

That structural trichotomy is finding expression in local turf wars. Take the brawl in Banda. BJP MLA Prakash Dwivedi, surrounded by a retinue, allegedly slapped sub-divisional Magistrate (SDM) Amit Shukla during a row over trucks seized for illegal sand mining. Police say the MLA tried to bamboozle officials into releasing two overloaded vehicles impounded at Paigambarpur crossing, but failed. Rage got physical, and the petty spat turned political. The Congress and the SP flagged the "*gundagardi*" and accused Dwivedi of shielding the local mining mafia.

The 'Delhi vs Lucknow' theme came through even in the long feud between Ashish Patel, state technical education minister, and his sister-in-law Pallavi Patel, who accuses him of corruption in promotions. He says top state bureaucrats conspired to damage him through leaks. An irked Yogi reportedly told him to stop airing grievances in the public realm. For now, that's exactly where all the soiled linen seems to be in UP. ■